

speaker' (that sounds like good headphones), which is also a comfortable lounge chair. You can thus surround yourself with the music of your choice. The music could be from your iPad, iMac, iPod or a laptop docked to the chair. Sonic chairs, winner of red-dot design award, could prove to be a great attraction at airport lounges, in hotel lobbies, at bookstores or music shops.

Then there were 3D multimedia glasses from Zeiss. Wearing them you can fantasize about being a helicopter pilot, or sitting comfortably in a movie theatre while on a dentist's chair. You can also view your favourite video game in 3D, or visualise the house you have been dreaming of. It has OLED display, interactive head tracker and -5 to +2 diopters eye-focusing. iPod/iPhone adaptor is optional.

We all know that HP produces 3D printers. But who else produces such printers? At least one other company could be seen demonstrating their low-cost 3D printer. And from where else could it be except China! They were quoting a price of \$ 600 fob, a piece, for a minimum of 50 printers. Controlled by a laptop, this printer can produce 3D objects, mostly toys for children, using ABS filaments available in up to seven colours with them.

Sego-like two-wheeled vehicles were demonstrated by another Chinese company. Capable of supporting a maximum of 100 kg, it can move up to 20 km on a single charge of its 48V, 8Ah lithium battery. Its price was quoted as around \$2200 a piece.

Information technology

Did you know Mexico is the third biggest IT services supplier globally, after India and the Philippines? And that Bangladesh is striving to be the next IT destination? And that South Africa also has a very well developed IT sector, which is a part of what it calls its electro-technical industry? In fact, many countries seem to be doing well in the field of IT, or are striving to catch up—at least that is the impression one got from CeBIT this year.

Big multinational IT companies like IBM, Microsoft, SAP and Dell were all there, of course, occupying huge areas. But Google and Facebook seemed to be missing.

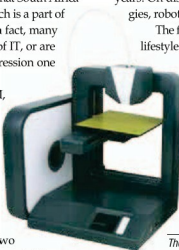
There were about twenty Indian IT services providers at the fair, at a place reserved for India. Software Technology Parks of India was also there among them. Kerala Technopark had taken a bigger pavilion elsewhere in the hall, where their two Kathakali dancers were a great attraction. Kerala's IT



Sonic chair



3D multimedia glasses from Zeiss



3D printer

secretary was also present at the stall. There were quite a few visitors from India. But none of the biggies like TCS, Wipro, Infosys and HCL could be seen anywhere.

Open source and cloud computing seemed to be the two favourite subjects this year. Many companies were seen promoting their products and services in these two sectors.

Business

Besides display of technology and innovations, there were serious business interactions going on, especially in areas reserved for the purpose. In some of these areas only the concerned persons were allowed after due diligence and registration.

Considered to be the world's largest business event for IT, the organisers of CeBIT said that they focused on quality rather than quantity. They have therefore stopped looking at just the number of exhibitors and visitors, or the area covered. They felt that the quality of meetings and visitors had improved this year as compared to the previous show, even though the quality was not bad even last year. This could be an indicator of good times coming.

CeBIT was divided into four groups, with CeBIT pro being the largest as it covered almost seventy per cent area of the show. It comprised major companies like IBM, Microsoft and SAP, who provide solutions for business operations.

The second group, CeBIT gov, showcased digital solutions for the government and private services. This sector is growing fast internationally.

The third group, CeBIT lab, showcased public and private R&D efforts. These products are not ready to market yet, but could be in the market in the next three to five years. On display were such high-tech subjects as 3D technologies, robotics, voice control and voice recognition.

The fourth group, CeBIT life, covered solutions for digital lifestyle. Here the entertainment part—as provided by Intel games—was separated from the business part.

The underlying theme of the fair visible everywhere was the way IT was changing the development of the society everywhere. Sharing is becoming a new way of life, whether through open source or cloud computing. Sharing is becoming popular in private life as well, whether it is through car pooling or social media.

The next CeBIT in Hannover is scheduled for 11th to 15th March, 2014. ●

The author is editor of EFY magazine. His visit to CeBIT was sponsored by the organisers